Unit - 3

Hydrological Cycle



Learning Objectives

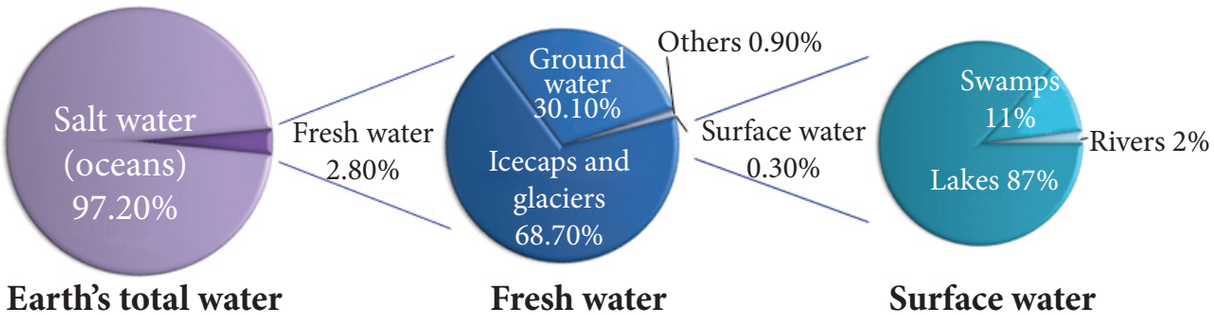
- To understand the status of water on the earth
- To learn the basic concepts of Hydrological cycle
- To study the different components of hydrological cycle

Introduction

Water is one of the most important elements on the earth. All plants and animals need water for survival. Apart from drinking, water is required for domestic, agriculture, industrial purposes etc. Water is very essential for carrying out almost all economic activities. So, water is an indispensable element without which life form on the earth is not possible.

Water on the Earth

About 71% of the earth's surface is covered by water. The quantity of water present on the earth is about 326 million cubic miles. It is hard to visualise this massive quantity of water. Most of the water on the earth is saline and is found in seas and oceans. The salt water constitutes about 97.20% and the fresh water is 2.80%. Out of this 2.80%, about 2.20% is available as surface water and the remaining 0.60% as groundwater. From this 2.20% of surface water, 2.15% is available in the form of glaciers and icecaps, 0.01% in lakes and streams and the remaining 0.04% is in other forms. Only about 0.60% of the total ground water can be economically extracted with the present drilling technology.



Water on the Earth

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